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CUET UG

English

Verbal Ability

Official Syllabus · Language Test (101) · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official Syllabus Pointer (NTA CUET UG 101)	Core Skills Tested
Rearranging Parts	Rearranging the parts: Scrambled sentences and paragraph reconstruction (Para Jumbles).	Identifying opening sentences, tracking pronoun-antecedent links, spotting discourse connectors.
Match the Following	Match the following: Two-column matrix pairings across vocabulary, idioms, and phrases.	Anchor-pairing, process of elimination, full matrix verification under time constraints.
Choosing Correct Word	Choosing the correct word: Cloze tests, sentence completion, and homophone discrimination.	Three-tier validation: contextual semantic sense, grammatical part of speech, collocation.
Synonyms & Antonyms	Synonyms and Antonyms: Contextual word meaning, semantic nuance, and antonym flipping.	Word sentiment charge $(+, 0, -)$, contextual substitution, eliminating synonym traps.

EXAM PATTERN

CUET UG 2027 Official Exam Pattern: The English Language section (Code 101) presents **50 compulsory multiple-choice questions** to be attempted in **60 minutes**. Each correct response yields $+5$ marks, while an incorrect response incurs a -1 mark negative deduction (unattempted questions earn 0). Verbal Ability comprises approximately **30 to 35 questions** (over 60% of the entire paper), spanning grammar, sentence rearrangement, vocabulary in context, idioms, and phrase substitutions. Because questions are discrete, a disciplined, rule-based solving method yields rapid and error-free marks.

The Cognitive Foundations of Verbal Ability

Verbal Ability in competitive examinations is frequently misconstrued as a test of rote dictionary memorization or intuitive "gut feelings." In reality, the National Testing Agency (NTA) constructs questions to evaluate four distinct cognitive pillars:

- **Structural Parsing:** Deconstructing complex sentences to evaluate subject-verb concord, pronoun antecedents, modifier placements, and parallel syntax.
- **Discourse Logic:** Organizing disjointed ideas into a coherent rhetorical narrative based on thematic progression, chronological flow, and logical causality.
- **Lexical Precision:** Discriminating between nuanced synonyms, identifying correct prepositions in phrasal verbs, and resolving homophones.
- **Evaluative Judgment:** Striking out distractor options engineered around sound-alike traps, partial-match illusions, and polarity reversals.

THE LEGO BRICK ANALOGY

Approaching Verbal Ability is like **assembling a model from mixed Lego bricks**. A scrambled paragraph is the picture on the box: you locate the flat corner foundation first (the opening noun sentence), connect obvious adjacent bricks (pronoun-antecedent pairs), and snap the closing roof in place. Sentence completion is finding the single brick whose physical contours (grammatical part of speech) and color (contextual tone) match the gap. Guessing by ear is trying to hammer a round peg into a square hole—it damages your score.

Rearranging the Parts: The Para Jumble Engine

A scrambled sentence or paragraph is an exercise in structural logic. Sentences in standard academic English are bound together by an intricate web of **grammatical signposts**. Identifying these signposts transforms a seemingly random puzzle into an inevitable sequence.

The Five Master Signpost Categories

1. **Noun-Pronoun Antecedent Chains:** A personal or demonstrative pronoun (**he, she, it, they, this, that, these, those**) cannot precede the specific noun it references. The sentence establishing the entity by name must always precede the sentence utilizing the pronoun.
2. **Proper Noun to Acronym Hierarchy:** Full names and expanded institutional designations invariably precede abbreviations (e.g., **The Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO)** must precede subsequent references to **ISRO** or **the space agency**).
3. **Chronological & Historical Flow:** Time markers establish natural temporal sequences (**in the early twentieth century → subsequently → by 1947 → modern day**). Historical progression rarely moves backward without overt flashback markers.
4. **Cause-and-Effect Connectors:** Connective adverbs (**consequently, therefore, as a corollary, hence, thus**) introduce outcomes and must directly succeed the sentences establishing the causal premise.
5. **General Statement to Specific Illustration:** Academic prose typically establishes a broad theoretical assertion or universal observation before introducing concrete case studies, historical anecdotes, or statistical proof.

The 5-Step Operational Solving Protocol

- **Step 1 — Eliminate False Openers:** Inspect the four given options to identify the proposed starting sentences. Instantly disqualify any sentence opening with a backward-pointing pronoun (**he, they, this**), an adversative conjunction (**however, but, nevertheless**), or an additive marker (**moreover, furthermore**).
- **Step 2 — Discover the Mandatory Pair:** Scan the sentences for two statements that are inseparable (e.g., a question followed immediately by its answer, or a hypothesis followed by its empirical test). If you establish that Sentence B must directly follow Sentence A (forming pair **AB**), eliminate every option that lacks the contiguous block **AB**.
- **Step 3 — Locate the Concluding Seal:** Identify which sentence delivers a terminal judgment, future outlook, or final summary.
- **Step 4 — Verify the Complete Sequence:** Re-read the reconstructed sequence end-to-end to verify that the narrative flows smoothly without jarring conceptual leaps.

PARA JUMBLE DECONSTRUCTION IN 30 SECONDS

Sentences:

- **P:** Subsequently, these localized disturbances coalesced into a severe cyclonic storm.
- **Q:** The meteorological department first recorded anomalous atmospheric depression over the Bay of Bengal on Monday morning.
- **R:** Coastal settlements were consequently evacuated within forty-eight hours to minimize casualties.
- **S:** Meteorologists observed that the depression was fueled by unusually warm surface waters.

Solving Path:

1. **Opener Hunt:** P begins with "Subsequently" (cannot open). R begins with "Coastal settlements were consequently…" (cannot open). Q introduces the phenomenon by full name ("meteorological department first recorded anomalous depression…"). **Sentence Q is the indisputable opener.**
2. **Mandatory Pair:** Q states a depression appeared → S explains what fueled that depression ("the depression was fueled by…"). Hence, **QS** is a mandatory pair.
3. **Progression:** After being fueled (S), it coalesced into a cyclonic storm (P) → leading to evacuations (R).

Resulting Sequence: Q → S → P → R.

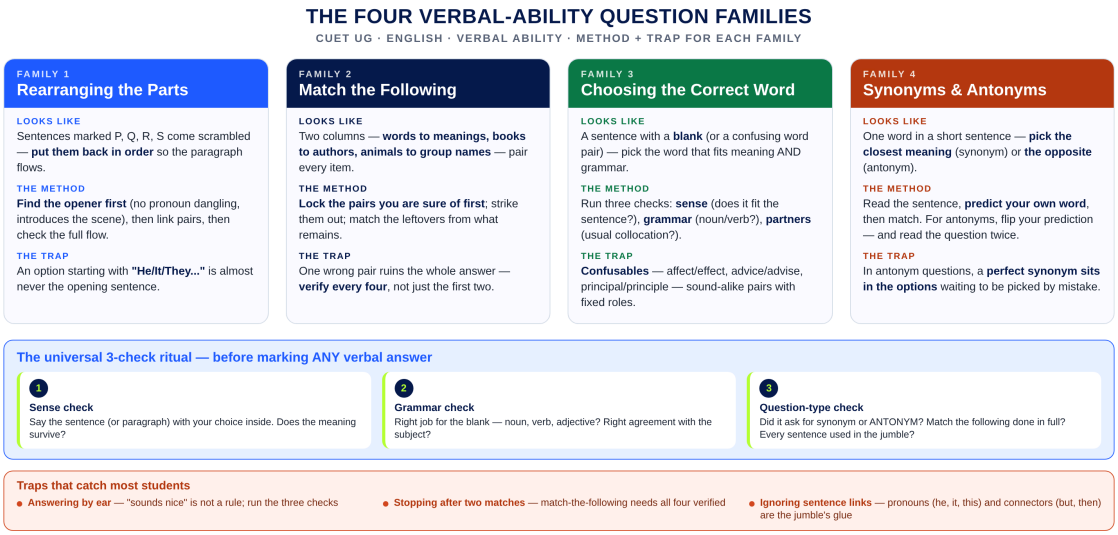


Figure 1: Systematic taxonomy of the four CUET Verbal Ability question families, outlining their operational solving routines, cognitive verification checks, and high-frequency traps.

Master Grammar & Syntactic Architecture

CUET error detection and sentence improvement questions rigorously test five core grammatical domains. Mastering these precise rules protects against the fatal habit of answering based on colloquial "sound."

1. Subject-Verb Agreement (Concord)

The fundamental rule mandates that a singular subject takes a singular verb, while a plural subject takes a plural verb. However, examiners introduce syntactic complexities to obscure the true subject:

- **Intervening Parenthetical Expressions:** Phrases introduced by **as well as, along with, together with, in addition to, accompanied by, including,** and **no less than** do NOT alter the number of the grammatical subject.
  - **Incorrect:** *The Prime Minister, along with his senior cabinet colleagues, have arrived.*
  - **Correct:** *The Prime Minister, along with his senior cabinet colleagues,* ***has*** *arrived.*
- **Correlative Conjunctions:** With **either...or, neither...nor,** and **not only...but also**, the finite verb agrees strictly with the **closer subject** (Rule of Proximity).
  - **Correct:** *Neither the principal nor the teachers* ***were*** *informed.*
  - **Correct:** *Neither the teachers nor the principal* ***was*** *informed.*
- **Indefinite Pronouns:** Pronouns such as **each, everyone, someone, anybody, either, neither,** and **one** are grammatically singular and require singular verbs and pronouns.
  - **Correct:** *Each of the participating universities* ***has*** *submitted* ***its*** *compliance report.*
- **Collective Nouns:** Nouns such as **committee, jury, council, faculty,** and **team** take a singular verb when operating as a single unified entity, but a plural verb when members act individually.
  - **Unified:** *The jury* ***has*** *reached its unanimous verdict.*
  - **Divided:** *The jury* ***were*** *divided in their opinions.*

2. Modifiers: Misplaced and Dangling Participles

A modifying participial phrase must be placed immediately adjacent to the noun or pronoun it logically describes:

- **Dangling Modifier:** Occurs when the intended subject of the participial phrase is absent from the main clause.
  - **Incorrect:** *Walking briskly through the campus, the clock tower struck midnight.* (Did the clock tower walk?)
  - **Correct:** *Walking briskly through the campus,* ***Rohit heard*** *the clock tower strike midnight.*
- **Misplaced Adverbs:** Words such as **only, merely, almost, just,** and **nearly** must stand directly before the word they modify. Notice how meaning alters:
  - *She* ***only*** *told me her secret.* (She did nothing else except tell me.)
  - *She told me* ***only*** *her secret.* (She revealed no other information.)

3. Parallelism in Series and Comparisons

Elements performing identical grammatical functions in a sentence must share identical grammatical form:

- **Coordinated Lists:** If a series begins with gerunds, every element must remain a gerund.
  - **Incorrect:** *Ravi enjoys swimming, to play tennis, and reading historical novels.*
  - **Correct:** *Ravi enjoys* ***swimming, playing*** *tennis, and* ***reading*** *historical novels.*
- **Comparative Structures:** Comparisons introduced by **than** or **as** must compare grammatically equivalent entities.
  - **Incorrect:** *The climate of Bengaluru is much more pleasant than Delhi.* (Compares climate to a city!)
  - **Correct:** *The climate of Bengaluru is much more pleasant than* ***that of*** *Delhi.*

4. Tenses and Sequence of Time

- **Past Perfect vs Simple Past:** When two actions occurred in the past, the earlier completed action requires the Past Perfect (**had + V3**), while the subsequent action requires the Simple Past (**V2**).
  - **Correct:** *The patient **had died** before the physician **arrived**.*
- **Conditional Sentences:**
  - **Type 1 (Probable):** *If it rains, we **will cancel** the match.* (Present Simple → Future Simple)
  - **Type 2 (Hypothetical):** *If I were the captain, I **would select** three spinners.* (Past Subjunctive → Would + V1)
  - **Type 3 (Counterfactual Past):** *If they **had alerted** the authorities, the disaster **would have been** averted.* (Past Perfect → Would have + V3)



Figure 2: Comprehensive architecture of CUET Verbal Ability: Detailing core syntactic rules, sentence rearrangement signposts, lexical acquisition models, and the 4-step solving protocol.

Lexical Precision: The Three-Tier Blank Solving Protocol

When tackling fill-in-the-blank questions (Cloze tests or sentence completions), candidates must apply three successive filters before selecting an option:

1. **The Semantic Sense Check:** Determine the necessary meaning of the missing word based on the overall sentence thesis. Identify whether the blank requires a positive, neutral, or negative term.
2. **The Grammatical Form Check:** Determine the exact part of speech required by syntactic position (e.g., does the blank follow an article requiring a noun, an auxiliary requiring a participle, or a verb requiring an adverb?).
3. **The Collocation & Partner Check:** Verify whether the word naturally pairs with surrounding prepositions and nouns in standard English idiom (e.g., one **submits** to authority, **adheres** to principles, **abstains** from vice).

The High-Frequency Confusables Reference Table

Examiners exploit pairs of words that share acoustic similarities but possess completely distinct grammatical roles and semantic definitions:

Confusable Pair	Word 1 (Role & Definition)	Word 2 (Role & Definition)
Affect / Effect	**Affect** (Verb): To influence or alter; **"Taxes affect spending."**	**Effect** (Noun): The result or consequence; **"The effect was immediate."**
Advice / Advise	**Advice** (Noun): An opinion or counsel given; **"He gave sound advice."**	**Advise** (Verb): The act of offering counsel; **"I advise extreme caution."**
Principal / Principle	**Principal** (Noun/Adj): Chief, head of school, capital sum.	**Principle** (Noun): A fundamental moral rule or scientific law.
Stationary / Stationery	**Stationary** (Adj): Fixed in position, immobile.	**Stationery** (Noun): Writing paper, envelopes, pens, and office supplies.
Complement / Compliment	**Complement** (Verb/Noun): To complete or balance perfectly.	**Compliment** (Verb/Noun): An expression of praise, admiration, or respect.
Discrete / Discreet	**Discrete** (Adj): Individually separate, distinct, disconnected.	**Discreet** (Adj): Prudent, circumspect, careful to avoid embarrassment.
Elicit / Illicit	**Elicit** (Verb): To draw forth or evoke a response or truth.	**Illicit** (Adj): Forbidden by law, rules, or societal custom; illegal.
Imminent / Eminent	**Imminent** (Adj): About to occur immediately; impending.	**Eminent** (Adj): High-ranking, distinguished, renowned, prominent.
Prescribe / Proscribe	**Prescribe** (Verb): To recommend, order, or direct authoritatively.	**Proscribe** (Verb): To ban, prohibit, forbid, or outlaw officially.
Council / Counsel	**Council** (Noun): An administrative or advisory assembly.	**Counsel** (Noun/Verb): Legal advice, guidance, or an attorney.

Etymological Word Power: Greek and Latin Roots

Memorizing individual words in isolation is inefficient. Mastering etymological roots allows candidates to infer the meanings of dozens of unfamiliar academic terms instantaneously:

Root	Primary Meaning	Derivative Academic Words in CUET
Bene-	Good, well, kind	Beneficial, benevolent (charitable), benefactor (patron), benediction (blessing).
Mal-	Bad, evil, harsh	Malicious (spiteful), malevolent (harmful), malady (illness), malignant (deadly).
Chron-	Time, temporal	Chronological (ordered in time), chronicle, chronic (long-lasting), synchronize.
Anthrop-	Human, mankind	Philanthropy (love of mankind), anthropology (study of humanity), misanthrope.
Loq- / Loc-	Speak, talk, discourse	Eloquent (fluent), loquacious (talkative), circumlocution (indirect speech), soliloquy.

Root	Primary Meaning	Derivative Academic Words in CUET
Path-	Feeling, disease, suffering	Empathy (shared feeling), antipathy (strong hatred), apathy (indifference), pathology.
Cred-	Believe, trust, faith	Credible (believable), credulous (gullible), incredible, creed (statement of belief).
Spect-	Look, examine, observe	Introspection (self-examination), circumspect (cautious), conspicuous (noticeable).
Vert- / Vers-	Turn, change direction	Avert (turn away), adversary (opponent), versatile (adaptable), inadvertent.

High-Yield Idioms, Phrasal Verbs & Foreign Phrases

CUET questions consistently evaluate idiomatic precision and common Latin loan expressions:

Critical Phrasal Verbs with Preposition Shifts

- **Give:** *Give in* (surrender) ≠ *Give up* (abandon effort) ≠ *Give out* (distribute or fail) ≠ *Give off* (emit fumes).
- **Break:** *Break down* (mechanical failure or emotional collapse) ≠ *Break out* (escape or sudden start of war) ≠ *Break off* (terminate negotiations).
- **Look:** *Look into* (investigate officially) ≠ *Look after* (care for) ≠ *Look down upon* (regard with contempt).
- **Call:** *Call off* (cancel completely) ≠ *Call on* (visit someone) ≠ *Call for* (demand or require).

Latin and Foreign Phrases in Standard Usage

- **De facto:** In reality or practice, whether officially sanctioned or not (contrasted with *de jure*, by law).
- **Bona fide:** In good faith; genuine, authentic, sincere (**"a bona fide offer"**).
- **Status quo:** The existing state of affairs or political/social conditions.
- **Prima facie:** Based on initial impression; accepted as correct until proven otherwise.
- **Per se:** In and of itself; intrinsically (**"The policy is not objectionable per se, but its execution is flawed"**).
- **Modus operandi (M.O.):** Particular manner or method of working, especially a criminal's operating procedure.
- **Ad hoc:** Created or formed for a particular purpose only; non-permanent (**"an ad hoc parliamentary committee"**).

Match the Following & Matrix Pairing Strategy

When approaching two-column matching questions (e.g., matching words to antonyms, idioms to meanings, or figures of speech to examples), follow the **Anchor and Strike Routine**:

1. **Identify the Absolute Certainty:** Scan Column I and Column II for the single pair you recognize with complete confidence.
2. **Eliminate Option Bundles:** Check the four multiple-choice options immediately. Discard every option that fails to reflect your confirmed anchor pair. This single step frequently eliminates two to three distractors.
3. **Pair the Residue:** Match the remaining two items from the severely reduced list of options.

4. **Verify the Complete Quad:** Before finalizing your answer, verify that all four pairs form valid correspondences.

One Word Substitution: The High-Yield CUET Catalog

One Word Substitution evaluates a student's ability to replace verbose, meandering clauses with precise lexical terminology. CUET items frequently draw from three thematic clusters:

Thematic Category	Target Concept / Phrase	Exact One-Word Substitution
Personality & Behavior	One who selflessly works for the welfare of others	**Altruist** (Philanthropist)
Personality & Behavior	One who doubts the sincerity and goodness of human motives	**Cynic**
Personality & Behavior	One who remains indifferent to both pleasure and pain	**Stoic**
Personality & Behavior	A person who speaks many languages fluently	**Polyglot** (Multilingual)
Personality & Behavior	A person displaying extraordinary skill in fine arts/music	**Virtuoso**
Governance & State	A government ruled by the wealthiest aristocratic class	**Plutocracy**
Governance & State	A state governed by religious authorities or divine guidance	**Theocracy**
Governance & State	Rule by a small, privileged, self-serving clique	**Oligarchy**
Governance & State	The complete absence of government or legal order; chaos	**Anarchy**
Literary & Memorial	An inscription written on a tombstone in memory of the dead	**Epitaph**
Literary & Memorial	A mournful poem or song lamenting the deceased	**Elegy**
Literary & Memorial	Occurring, awarded, or published after a person's death	**Posthumous**
Specialized Science	The scientific study of the origin and history of words	**Etymology**
Specialized Science	The scientific study and observation of birds	**Ornithology**

Verbal Analogies: Architectural Taxonomy

Analogies test the candidate's capacity to recognize relational logic between word pairs and identify identical structural parallels across answer options.

```
[ A : B  ::  C : D ]
(As A is related to B, so C is related to D)
```

High-Frequency Analogy Relationships in CUET

- **Worker and Instrument:** The practitioner and their specialized tool.
  - *Surgeon : Scalpel :: Sculptor : Chisel* (A scalpel is the definitive tool of a surgeon; a chisel of a sculptor).
- **Degree of Intensity:** An escalation from moderate to extreme intensity.
  - *Warm : Scalding :: Pleased : Ecstatic* (Scalding is intensely warm; ecstatic is intensely pleased).
- **Part to Whole (Meronymy):** A structural component and its integrated entity.
  - *Spoke : Wheel :: Chapter : Novel* (A spoke is a vital part of a wheel; a chapter of a novel).
- **Cause and Corollary:** A physical stimulus and its natural consequence.
  - *Friction : Heat :: Sedentary Lifestyle : Obesity* (Friction generates heat; inactivity generates obesity).
- **Definitional Quality / Characteristic:** An inherent, non-negotiable trait.
  - *Fox : Cunning :: Lead : Malleable* (A fox is characteristically cunning; lead is characteristically malleable).

Advanced Syntax: Inversion, Redundancy, and the Subjunctive

Beyond basic subject-verb agreement, CUET tests advanced syntactic constraints that frequently trip students answering by colloquial ear.

1. Negative Adverbial Inversion

When a negative or restrictive adverbial expression introduces a clause, standard subject-verb order is **inverted** (Auxiliary Verb precedes Subject):

- **Negative Restrictors: Hardly, Scarcely, Barely, No sooner, Seldom, Little, Never before, Under no circumstances**.
  - **Incorrect:** *Hardly I had stepped out when it started pouring.*
  - **Correct:** *Hardly **had I** stepped out **when** it started pouring.*
  - **Incorrect:** *No sooner she received the letter when she wept.*
  - **Correct:** *No sooner **did she receive** the letter **than** she wept.* (Note: **No sooner** pairs strictly with **than**, never **when**).

2. Tautology and Redundancy Traps

Examiners frequently introduce unnecessary repetitious words that violate stylistic conciseness:

- **Revert back** → Use simply **revert** (revert already signifies returning).
- **Repeat again** → Use simply **repeat**.
- **Equally as good as** → Use **equally good** or **as good as**.
- **Mutual agreement** → Use **agreement** (agreements are inherently mutual).
- **Sufficient enough** → Use **sufficient** or **enough**.

3. The Mandative Subjunctive Mood

Verbs expressing formal demands, recommendations, or requirements (**insist, recommend, propose, demand, mandate, decree**) take a subordinate clause with the base form of the verb (infinitive without **to**), regardless of the subject's grammatical number:

- **Incorrect:** *The committee recommended that the candidate **submits** her dossier.*
- **Correct:** *The committee recommended that the candidate **submit** her dossier.*
- **Incorrect:** *The magistrate ordered that the prisoner **is** remanded.*

- **Correct:** *The magistrate ordered that the prisoner* ***be*** *remanded.*

Tactical Speed & Error Audit Protocol

The Verbal Ability section rewards algorithmic pacing. Candidates must complete discrete grammar and vocabulary questions in **35 to 45 seconds**, reserving saved time for reading comprehension passages:

Question Family	Time Target	Tactical Execution Routine
Vocabulary & Confusables	25–35 sec	Predict replacement word; check charge $(+, 0, -)$; eliminate sound-alikes.
Sentence Rearrangement	45–55 sec	Find false openers; lock mandatory pairs; match option choices; test full flow.
Grammar & Error Detection	30–40 sec	Deconstruct subject-verb concord; check modifiers; inspect parallelism.
Match the Following	30–40 sec	Anchor absolute certainty pair; eliminate mismatched option bundles; verify quad.

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Chapter Synthesis & Cognitive Mindmap



Figure 3: Comprehensive architectural mindmap of CUET Verbal Ability: Synthesizing the four question families, core syntactic rules, sentence rearrangement signposts, word power habits, and exam-day pacing.

HIGH-YIELD MEMORY HOOKS FOR CUET 2027 VERBAL ABILITY

Keep these fundamental grammatical and operational maxims primed:

- **Intervening Phrases:** “As well as”, “along with”, “together with” do NOT change subject number. Ignore them when picking the verb!
- **Rule of Proximity:** With “either…or” and “neither…nor”, the verb agrees strictly with the **closer subject**.
- **Dangling Modifiers:** The introductory participle must logically modify the immediate next noun. Watch out for rolling water bottles and walking clocks!
- **The Jumble Opener:** A sentence with a dangling pronoun (“He”, “It”, “They”, “This”) can NEVER open a paragraph.
- **Antonym Flip:** Always predict your own replacement word and **flip it** before looking at the options to dodge the synonym bait.
- **Confusables Concord:** Affect = Verb (influence); Effect = Noun (result). Advise = Verb; Advice = Noun. Principle = Rule; Principal = Chief/Head.

MASTER STRATEGY CHEATSHEET — VERBAL ABILITY

1. Core Grammar Rules:

$$\text{Subject} + \left[\frac{\text{as well as}}{\text{along with}} + \text{Object}\right] + \text{VERB (agrees with Subject 1)}$$

Either S_1 or S_2 VERB (S_2 governs concord), Neither S_1 nor S_2 VERB (S_2 governs concord)

$$\text{Negative Inversion: } \frac{\frac{\text{Hardly}}{\text{Scarcely}}}{\text{Barely}} + \text{had} + S + V_3 + \text{when}$$

$$\text{No sooner} + \frac{\text{did}}{\text{had}} + S + \frac{V_1}{V_3} + \text{than}$$

2. Sentence Rearrangement (Para Jumble) Sequence:

Opener Hunt (Noun, not pronoun) → Mandatory Pair Lock → Option Elimination → Full Narrative Verification

3. Three-Tier Blank Checking Routine:

- **Sense:** Contextual polarity $(+, 0, -)$ and logical semantic meaning.
- **Grammar:** Syntactic role (Noun, Verb, Adjective, Adverb, Participle).
- **Collocation:** Natural prepositional partnership (**adhere to, abstain from, comply with**).

4. Two-Column Matching Technique:

Anchor Single Known Pair → Eliminate Non-conforming Options → Verify Remaining Residual Quad

THE SEVEN FATAL CUET TRAPS IN VERBAL ABILITY

1. **The Colloquial Ear Trap:** Choosing an option because it "sounds natural" in casual speech. Colloquial English is riddled with grammatical violations (e.g., "Between you and I" instead of "Between you and me").
2. **The Attractive Synonym Bait in Antonym Questions:** Selecting a synonym because it matches the word's meaning. Always circle the stem word "OPPOSITE" and perform the mental flip!
3. **The Pronoun Jumble Opener Trap:** Falling for an option that opens with a pronoun sentence ("It slowly darkened…"). A true opener establishes the subject by name.
4. **The Intervening Phrase Concord Confusion:** Treating "along with his friends" as pluralizing the subject. Only the word before the comma governs the verb.
5. **The Confusable Acoustic Illusion:** Swapping **affect** and **effect**, **stationary** and **stationery**, or **principal** and **principle** based on identical pronunciation.
6. **The No Sooner 'When' Error:** Pairing **No sooner** with **when** instead of **than**. **Hardly/Scarcely** take **when**; **No sooner** takes **than**.
7. **The Partial Match Mirage in Two-Column Matching:** Marking an option after verifying only two pairs. Examiners craft options where two pairs are correct but the other two are swapped!

Practice Questions — Part 1: Vocabulary & Word Power (Q1 to Q5)

Q1. In the sentence "The finance minister offered a candid appraisal of the fiscal deficit, admitting that previous forecasts were overly optimistic," the word "candid" most nearly means:

(A) secretive, guarded, and evasive
(B) highly flattering and polite
(C) frank, truthful, and straightforward
(D) complex and difficult to grasp

Sol. Q1. Contextual substitution: The minister was admitting past overly optimistic forecasts, indicating unvarnished honesty. Replacing "candid" with "frank, truthful, and straightforward" preserves semantic meaning perfectly. Option A is an antonym; Option B is opposite in tone; Option D misidentifies the concept. **Answer: (C)**

Q2. Choose the word that is MOST NEARLY OPPOSITE in meaning to the underlined word: "Fame on modern social media platforms is notoriously *ephemeral*, often fading before the season ends."

(A) transient and short-lived
(B) enduring, permanent, and lasting
(C) chaotic and disorganized
(D) celebrated and prestigious

Sol. Q2. Antonym flip routine: "Ephemeral" means lasting for a very short time (transient). Its direct opposite is "enduring, permanent, and lasting" (Option B). Option A is the classic synonym trap waiting to catch candidates who fail to flip their prediction; Options C and D are irrelevant. **Answer: (B)**

Q3. Fill in the blanks with the appropriate pair of words: "The senior advocate offered sound _____ regarding the property dispute, and she agreed to _____ her client to accept the out-of-court settlement."

(A) advise; advice
(B) advice; advise
(C) advices; advising
(D) advise; advise

Sol. Q3. Grammatical form check: The first blank follows an adjective ("sound _____") requiring a NOUN—**advice**. The second blank follows an infinitive marker ("agreed to _____") requiring a VERB—**advise**. Hence, the correct sequence is **advice; advise** (Option B). "Advices" is non-standard in English. **Answer: (B)**

Q4. Identify the sentence that uses the underlined phrasal verb INCORRECTLY:

(A) Due to torrential monsoon rain, the tournament committee decided to *call off* the championship.
(B) The government constituted an independent panel to *look into* allegations of administrative fraud.
(C) After weeks of intense siege, the isolated garrison finally *gave off* to the advancing army.
(D) The unprecedented public health crisis *called for* immediate and decisive fiscal intervention.

Sol. Q4. Idiomatic precision: To surrender or yield to an opponent is to **give in** (or **give up**). The phrasal verb **give off** signifies emitting gas, heat, or fumes (e.g., "The burning wood gave off toxic smoke"). Therefore, sentence C uses the phrasal verb incorrectly. **Answer: (C)**

Q5. Match the idioms in Column I with their correct meanings in Column II:

Column I (Idiom)	Column II (Meaning)
1. Burn the midnight oil	(a) Face an inevitable, painful situation with fortitude
2. Bite the bullet	(b) Deliberately ignore an unethical or unlawful act
3. Turn a blind eye	(c) Work or study diligently late into the night
4. At the eleventh hour	(d) At the very last possible moment before a deadline

(A) 1-c, 2-a, 3-b, 4-d
(B) 1-a, 2-c, 3-d, 4-b
(C) 1-c, 2-d, 3-a, 4-b
(D) 1-b, 2-a, 3-c, 4-d

Sol. Q5. Anchor-and-strike routine: Lock known pairs: "Burn the midnight oil" = study late (1-c) and "At the eleventh hour" = at the last moment (4-d). Looking at the options, only Option A pairs 1-c and 4-d. Verifying the rest: "Bite the bullet" = face hardship bravely (2-a); "Turn a blind eye" = deliberately ignore (3-b). All four verified ✓. **Answer: (A)**

Practice Questions — Part 2: Grammar & Error Detection (Q6 to Q10)

Q6. Identify the grammatically correct sentence among the following:

(A) The chief architect, along with his entire structural design team, have received the national award.
(B) The chief architect, along with his entire structural design team, has received the national award.
(C) The chief architect, along with his entire structural design team, are receiving the national award.
(D) The chief architect, along with his entire structural design team, were honoured at the convention.

Sol. Q6. Subject-verb concord: The true grammatical subject is singular ("The chief architect"). Parenthetical phrases introduced by "along with", "as well as", or "together with" do not alter the subject's number. Therefore, the verb must be singular (**has received**). Options A, C, and D commit plural verb errors. **Answer: (B)**

Q7. Fill in the blank with the grammatically correct verb form: "Neither the laboratory director nor the apprentice technicians _____ aware of the hazardous chemical leakage."

(A) was
(B) is
(C) were
(D) has been

Sol. Q7. Rule of Proximity: In compound subjects connected by **neither...nor** or **either...or**, the finite verb agrees strictly with the closer subject. The closer subject is plural ("apprentice technicians"). Therefore, the plural past verb **were** is required (Option C). Options A, B, and D use singular verb forms. **Answer: (C)**

Q8. Which of the following sentences contains an error of a DANGLING MODIFIER?

(A) While hiking up the steep mountain trail, my water bottle slipped and rolled down the cliff.
(B) Walking briskly along the coastal promenade, Rohit watched the fishing trawlers return.
(C) Having completed the forensic accounting review, the auditor submitted his final report.
(D) After waiting on the platform for three hours, the commuters finally boarded the delayed train.

Sol. Q8. Dangling modifier analysis: In sentence A, the introductory participial phrase "While hiking up the steep mountain trail" is immediately followed by "my water bottle". This illogically asserts that the water bottle was hiking up the mountain! The correct sentence requires a human subject: "While hiking up the steep mountain trail, **I dropped** my water bottle…". **Answer: (A)**

Q9. Select the option that best improves the underlined portion: "The elite business school curriculum emphasizes developing analytical thinking, fostering civic leadership, and *to cultivate ethical decision-making*."

(A) to cultivate ethical decision-making
(B) cultivation of ethical decision-making
(C) having cultivated ethical decision-making
(D) cultivating ethical decision-making

Sol. Q9. Parallelism in series: Elements in a coordinate list must maintain identical grammatical forms. The series establishes gerunds: **developing** analytical thinking, **fostering** civic leadership, and therefore requires **cultivating** ethical decision-making (Option D). Infinitives or nouns violate parallel structure. **Answer: (D)**

Q10. Select the grammatically correct completion for the counterfactual conditional sentence: "If the disaster management authority _____ timely flood warnings, the rescue teams _____ the submerged villages."

(A) issued; would evacuate
(B) would have issued; would evacuate
(C) had issued; would have evacuated
(D) has issued; had evacuated

Sol. Q10. Conditional Type 3 (Counterfactual Past): Refers to an unreal past condition and its probable past result. The **if-clause** requires the Past Perfect (**had + V3**), while the main clause requires **would have + V3**. Therefore, "had issued; would have evacuated" (Option C) is the sole grammatically valid structure. **Answer: (C)**

Practice Questions — Part 3: Para Jumbles, Analogies & One Word (Q11 to Q15)

Q11. Rearrange the sentences (P, Q, R, S) into a coherent, logical paragraph: **P:** It possesses the remarkable capability to camouflage itself by altering its skin pigmentation and texture in milliseconds. **Q:** Marine biologists consider the common octopus to be one of the most intellectually sophisticated invertebrates on Earth. **R:** This instantaneous physiological adaptation allows it to evade apex predators such as sharks and moray eels. **S:** In controlled laboratory trials, it has demonstrated complex spatial navigation, problem-solving, and tool usage. The correct order is:

(A) Q S P R **(B)** P R Q S
(C) Q P S R **(D)** S Q P R

Sol. Q11. Structural sequencing: Sentence Q introduces the subject by name ("Marine biologists consider the common octopus…"). Sentence S expands on its intellectual sophistication (problem-solving, tool usage). Sentence P introduces its physiological camouflage ability ("It possesses the remarkable capability…"). Sentence R connects directly to P via demonstrative reference ("This instantaneous physiological adaptation…"). Hence, **PR** is a mandatory pair. Sequence: **Q → S → P → R** (Option A). **Answer: (A)**

Q12. Rearrange the sentences (P, Q, R, S) into a meaningful chronological paragraph: **P:** In 1969, this pioneering research body was formally reorganized as the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). **Q:** Over subsequent decades, ISRO achieved international acclaim by executing lunar and interplanetary missions with unprecedented efficiency. **R:** India's modern space endeavors commenced in 1962 with the founding of the Indian National Committee for Space Research (INCOSPAR). **S:** Its founding chairman, Dr. Vikram Sarabhai, insisted that space science must address tangible societal challenges rather than mere geopolitical prestige. The correct order is:

(A) P Q R S **(B)** R S P Q
(C) S R P Q **(D)** R P S Q

Sol. Q12. Chronological & acronym hierarchy: Sentence R sets the historical origin (1962, INCOSPAR). Sentence S follows R immediately, detailing its founder Dr. Sarabhai's vision. Sentence P documents the 1969 evolution into ISRO ("this pioneering research body was formally reorganized as ISRO"). Sentence Q describes subsequent modern achievements. Order: **R → S → P → Q** (Option B). **Answer: (B)**

Q13. Complete the verbal analogy by selecting the option with identical relational logic: **SCALPEL : SURGEON :: _____ : _____**

(A) stethoscope : patient **(B)** canvas : painter
(C) courtroom : attorney **(D)** chisel : sculptor

Sol. Q13. Analogy relationship: Worker and Primary Precision Cutting Tool. A surgeon uses a scalpel to execute their craft; similarly, a sculptor uses a chisel to carve their sculpture (Option D). A patient does not use a stethoscope; a canvas is the recipient surface, not the painter's tool; a courtroom is the lawyer's workplace, not an instrument. **Answer: (D)**

Q14. A person who remains entirely indifferent to both pleasure and pain, enduring hardships and adversity without complaint or display of emotion, is designated as a:

(A) Hedonist **(B)** Altruist
(C) Stoic **(D)** Polyglot

Sol. Q14. One Word Substitution: A **Stoic** is one who practices stoicism—enduring suffering without demonstrating grief or passion. A **Hedonist** believes pleasure is the supreme good (opposite); an **Altruist** lives for the welfare of others; a **Polyglot** speaks multiple languages. **Answer: (C)**

Q15. Select the sentence that uses the Latin legal phrase "*bona fide*" correctly in standard English:

(A) The Supreme Court issued a *bona fide* writ compelling the state legislature to dissolve immediately.
(B) The board meeting dissolved into complete *bona fide* after the directors failed to achieve consensus.
(C) The construction contract was terminated *bona fide* because the firm violated essential workplace safety codes.
(D) Before approving the commercial loan, the credit officer verified that the entrepreneur was a *bona fide* trader with authentic business documentation.

Sol. Q15. Contextual usage: **Bona fide** is a Latin phrase signifying "in good faith; genuine, authentic, sincere, without fraud." Describing a "bona fide trader with authentic business documentation" (Option D) is the precise standard legal and commercial usage. In Options A, B, and C, it is inappropriately substituted for mandamus, chaos, and punitive termination. **Answer: (D)**